

1901–1914

SPORT AND COUNTRY

Garments initially developed for sportswear were often modified or appropriated for mainstream fashion. The most popular example from the male wardrobe were knee breeches of various widths and shapes called either knickerbockers, apparently after the garment worn by 17th-century Dutch settlers in America, or plus fours that extended 10cm (4in) below the knee. Before World War I knee breeches were rarely seen away from the shooting ground or the golf course. Now they formed part of smart suits worn in town. Other garments that were used for sport were cardigans for tennis, cricket, and baseball as well as increasingly for leisure wear, and thick, woollen sweaters seen on motorcyclists and skiers. Woollen jumpers were also popular with fishermen – workwear being another source for fashion innovation. Sportswear remained modest, however, and the male body was mostly hidden except at the beach where male swimming costumes became increasingly revealing, although they did not shrink into mere trunks until after World War II.

Tweed This gentleman sports a Norfolk jacket, made fashionable by the Prince of Wales in the 1860s. A popular part of golf attire, it was originally developed for shooting. It was always single-breasted, with box pleats in the front and back, and a belt or half-belt.

Flat cap

Formal wing collar

Front box pleat

1900

Patch pocket

Knickerbockers

Thick, woollen socks

Leather golf shoes

Leather cap, worn with goggles

Thin shoulder straps

Lower part often in two layers

Thick, woollen jumper

Gauntlets

Long, leather gaiters

1909

1911

Woollen swimwear The marathon swimmer S.S. Nichol wears an all-in-one swimsuit, probably made of heavy, machine-knitted wool, which lost its shape when wet. Non-professional male bathers usually wore short trousers with a separate vest.

Leather gaiters The British racing driver Oscar Godfrey poses with his motorcycle during the British Motorcycle Race Club Trials at Brooklands, England. He wears very long gaiters (leg coverings that fasten over his shoes and stretch up to his knees), probably over knickerbockers.